



SMART BREVITY

The Power of Saying More with Less

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The Big "So What"

Are you tired of writing long emails and reports that no one reads? Imagine if your messages could stand out and be understood in seconds. Smart Brevity shows you how to communicate clearly and efficiently, so you get your point across with less effort and more impact. Whether you're a student, leader, or professional, these strategies will help you to get noticed and remembered.



What is Smart Brevity and Why It Matters



In a digital age, people are suffering from information overload and constant distractions.

- This has fundamentally changed the way we consume content, and reduced our attention span. On average, we:
 - (i) Check our phones >344 times a day (at least every 4 minutes);
 - (ii) Scan content on our screens instead of reading them;
 - (iii) Spend only 26 seconds on a piece of content;
 - (iv) Spend less than 15 seconds on most web pages we visit;
 - (v) Decide in 17 milliseconds whether we like something we clicked (and if not, we move on); and
 - (vi) Share most stories without even reading them.
- People have no time or patience for lengthy texts. Yet we continue to ramble ineffectively in our daily communication. We write an entire book when the ideas can fit in a 1000-word

KEY QUOTES

"You will learn to punch through the noise, be heard on what matters most and win recognition for your most important ideas."

"It has never been harder to get people focused on what matters most."

"Never in the history of humanity have we vomited more words in more places with more velocity."

"We consume all kinds of digital content in short bursts, then quickly move on."

article, or write a long article when the ideas can fit in 1 paragraph.

- To be influential, you must communicate with crystal clarity. After all, you can't unite people behind an idea or strategy if they can't understand your message, or if they tune out altogether.



Smart Brevity is a more effective way to think and communicate in a noisy digital world. It helps you to say more with less, convey your message powerfully, and save everyone time.

- The authors initially developed Smart Brevity during their time at Politico and refined it further at their media company, Axios. They've since created Axios HQ—an AI-powered platform designed to help people communicate effectively using Smart Brevity.
- In this summary, we'll explain (i) how Smart Brevity works, followed by (ii) ways to apply Smart Brevity in real life.



How Smart Brevity Works



Research data shows that most people just read the headlines and the first few paragraphs of any article/story they see. They will read the rest of the article only if you hook their interest upfront.



Smart Brevity is built on several principles for effective communication, with 4 core elements to be applied in any communication.

- These are meant to serve as guidelines to help you think and write more effectively; they're not strict rules to be followed rigidly.

KEY QUOTES

"You can't rally people around a strategy or an idea if they don't understand what you're saying—or zone out."

*"I didn't have time to write you a short letter, so I wrote you a long one."
—Mark Twain*

"If you want vital information to stick in the digital world, you need to radically rethink—and repackage—how you deliver it."

*"Brevity is confidence.
Length is fear."*

*"These are guardrails,
not hard-and-fast,
never-break-them rules."*

KEY QUOTES

"Smart Brevity will make your messages clear and memorable, so everyone stays aligned and inspired."

"Just say what you mean, sincerely and short."

"There's a foolproof way to know if you have a good attention grabber: Would you read it if you hadn't written it?"

"Smart Brevity is music theory—it gives you logic and elegance. But that magnificent architecture leaves room for... jazz."

The 4 Cores of Smart Brevity

These 4 elements form the backbone for effective communication.

Muscular Tease



Have a headline or subject line of 6 words or less.

Lede



In the first sentence, state ONE Big Thing they should take away.

Why It Matters



Offer context on why your idea or message matters to them.

Option to Go Deeper



Give people the choice to learn more if they wish.



"Muscular tease" or an attention-grabbing headline/subject.

- Your audience will make a split-second decision on whether to read your content. Make sure your subject line or headline (or the first line of your Tweets/notes) can grab their attention, and yank them away from other distractions.
- Get right to the point, ideally keeping to 6 words or less. Avoid technical terms, jargon, and don't try to be funny or clever—you will just confuse your audience.
- Start by expressing why you're writing this content in 10 words or less, then reduce it to fewer words.
 - (i) Express your idea in a provocative but accurate way.
 - (ii) Use short, strong words that zing.
 - (iii) Always use active verbs.
- Read your headline aloud. Does it sound like something you'd be curious to learn more about? Refine it until you're satisfied.
- Additional tips:
 - (i) Consider adding a famous name/brand that your audience relates to (e.g. Warren Buffett for investors).
 - (ii) Useful content like "tips" and "free training" tends to increase engagement.

- Here are several examples:

Example	Bad	Good
News Headline	An Overview of the Latest Developments in AI Technology	AI Breakthrough: What's Next?
Workplace Update	Please be reminded that the quarterly review meeting will take place next week.	Quarterly Review: Prepare Now.
Health and Wellness	Why It's Important to Stay Hydrated Throughout the Day	Hydration: 5 Key Benefits



"Lede" or an effective opening sentence.

- In the first sentence after the headline, state the ONE thing you want people to take away. Lead with the most important idea, because it's probably the only thing your audience will recall later. If you don't know this, your reader won't either.
- Distill down to your most crucial point. This should be something your audience doesn't know, wants to know, or should know.
- Be direct, clear, and succinct.
 - (i) Keep to 1 sentence, without repeating the headline.
 - (ii) Skip the anecdotes, adverbs, weak words, or extra words.
 - (iii) Check your 1 thing by asking: If this is the ONLY thing that sticks, is it what you want them to remember? If the answer is "no", rework it until you get a "yes".
- Here are several examples:

Example	Bad	Good
Sharing Vital News	I wanted to let you know that something significant has happened. We're merging with XYZ Corp, and I think it's going to change things for us moving forward.	Big change coming: We're merging with XYZ Corp.

KEY QUOTES

"Make news and information not just smart, but as clean and efficient as possible."

"The first sentence is your one—and likely only—chance to tell someone what they need to know and convince them not to move on."

"If there is one thing you take away from this book, it is this: Learn to identify and trumpet ONE thing you want people to know."

"One of the media's dirty little secrets is that most journalists suck at writing tight ledes. So don't feel bad: They're paid to do it, and they struggle."

Example	Bad	Good
Discussing a Critical Issue	I've been thinking about the recent challenges we've faced, and I believe there's something we need to address.	Our biggest client is unhappy—we need to act.
Asking for Support	I'm reaching out because I could really use some help with a new project that's been assigned to me.	I need your support on a new project.



The context or “Why It Matters.” Most people are too busy to read and digest a piece of content in detail; they will only skim through it. Offer some context on why your idea, fact, or message matters to them personally or professionally.

- Use the words “Why It Matters” to capture their interest. Then, explain clearly and succinctly why they should care.
- Be direct, and declarative. Tell them what/how to think about the opening line. Offer perspectives like: What does it signal or change? Is there a wider context like a trend or an anomaly?
- Besides “Why it matters”, you can use other axioms like: The Big Picture, What's Next, What We're Reading, Between the Lines, The Backstory, Zoom In, Zoom out.
- Bold the words so they stand out like a street sign.
- Your headline, lede and axiom should jointly convey your main message clearly and directly. From there, they can decide whether to keep reading.



Option to “go deeper”: Give people the choice to learn more if they want to.

- Include a link to additional details (e.g. video, podcast, bio, book excerpts). This allows you to deliver depth and detail, while keeping your content lean and elegant.
- Use axioms like “Go Deeper”, “The Big Picture”, or “Learn more.” Bold the axioms so they stand out.
- Make sure the additional details are really worth your readers' time.

KEY QUOTES

“Most people are too busy to understand not just what is important, but why it's important. Be a hero: Tell them in a brisk, clear, illuminating way.”

“People are crazy busy. They yearn for context. Scratch that itch for your reader.”

“Simply seeing the ‘Go deeper’ material shows the reader that you're on their side...It says: I've done the work so you don't have to.”



Let's combine the 4 Cores into an example below:

4 Cores	Example
Muscular Tease	AI revolutionizes medical diagnostics.
First Sentence (Lede)	A new AI system now diagnoses cancer with 98% accuracy, outperforming top human doctors.
Why It Matters (Context)	This AI advancement could drastically reduce misdiagnosis rates, saving thousands of lives annually and cutting healthcare costs by billions. Early, accurate detection means treatment can start sooner, increasing survival rates and improving patient outcomes.
Option to Go Deeper	Explore how this AI works, its real-world applications, and what it means for the future of healthcare in our full report.



Guiding Principles of Effective Communication

Smart Brevity is built on several powerful principles, which we have distilled and reorganized below.



It's all about brevity: being short, but not shallow.

- Aim to do more with less. Pack more into your communication, using arresting headlines, effective graphics, fewer but stronger words and sentences.
- However, be careful not to lose the nuances, oversimplify concepts, or omit vital facts. There are also exceptions where brevity isn't the ideal, such as in poetry, nonfiction books, or casual conversations.



Always put your audience first. Prioritize your audience's needs to ensure your message is relevant and engaging.

- Visualize your target audience, focusing on just **ONE** person you're targeting. Imagine someone smart, curious, but extremely busy.
- Tailor your message specifically to that person. What's the **ONE** thing you want them to remember? Consider what they want or need to know, not what you wish to say.

KEY QUOTES

"We hide the good stuff in piles of words. We make people deduce what we're trying to say instead of just blurting it out. Don't be fancy—be effective."

"We committed to stop wasting people's time...To open their eyes to the idea that less is more, and that short does not mean shallow."

"Don't omit important facts or nuance, oversimplify or dumb down. 'Short, not shallow,' is what we tell our reporters."

"Tightly tailor your message to your target reader."

"We tend to think too much about what we want to say versus what others need to hear."



Respect their time and intelligence. Be brief and clear, ensuring what you're saying is worth saying.

- Write down the points you wish to make, rank them in order of importance, then filter down to the most important points. Do a gut check: is every point truly essential?
- Write these down as bullet points, not chunks of text. Go through your sentences word by word. Polish them to the fewest possible words, using strong, crisp, vivid, and memorable language. Make every word count.
- Don't force them to wade through lengthy preambles and fluff. Get right to the point, then stop. Don't blabber on.



Write as a human, for humans. Speak plainly, as if you're communicating 1-1 with someone.

- Write the way you speak. Keep it clear, direct, authentic, and relatable.
- Be inclusive. Communicate in a way that anyone—regardless of their background, level of expertise, or personal circumstances—can understand. This involves:
 - (i) Using clear, simple language, not jargon and technical terms;
 - (ii) Tailoring your communication for diverse backgrounds, e.g. cultural, linguistic, and educational differences; and
 - (iii) Making your messages accessible to all, including those with disabilities. For example, include visuals with alternative texts, and include captions for videos.



Speak with authority: You need expertise in order to communicate effectively and credibly.

- An expert has a deep understanding of their field, can assess what's new or important, and has the ability to distill their know-how into clear, actionable insights.
- If you're not an expert, then find an expert. Make sure the information you share is accurate, relevant, and valuable.



Convey information in the simplest and cleanest way.

- Limit each paragraph to 2-3 sentences. Break down clumps

KEY QUOTES

"Writing is like a stacked buffet, where it's up to you to pick and choose what you want."

"In a world full of noise, people reward you if you respect their time and intelligence."

"If you're not communicating inclusively, you're not communicating effectively."

"Once you see yourself as serving your audience, people take notice, reward you, trust you, welcome you and actually read or listen to you."

"Smart Brevity jams essential information into the most digestible and delicious packaging."

- Emojis are useful 👍 for conveying emotion, intent, and nuances. Used appropriately, they help us to say more with less 💡. Some examples in business include:

(i) Data or poll 📊

(ii) Perfect: 🎯

(iii) Deadline: ⌚

(iv) Restaurant review: 🍽️👍

(v) Checkmark: ✅

(vi) Goal or Target: 🎯

- Here's a quick recap of the key principles discussed so far:



KEY QUOTES

"Emojis as a powerful tool for business and casual communication when used wisely, cleverly and—most important—with restraint."

"Emojis as a powerful tool for business and casual communication when used wisely, cleverly and—most important—with restraint."

"An emoji in a subject line will make it instantly stand out in your inbox. Try it and you'll quickly see the effect."



How to Apply Smart Brevity (SB) in Real Life

You can use the 4 Cores and guiding principles of Smart Brevity in all your communications to increase your impact and save time for everyone.



Newsletters. People hate long reports, emails and memos, but they will love a newsletter done in SB format. This is a great way to share impactful information and get everyone on the same page.

- Choose a catchy name for the newsletter that conveys your ethos and purpose in 1-2 words.
- Clearly indicate your wordcount and how long it will take to read the newsletter. The average reading speed is 265 words a minute.
- Start with your 1 big thing in the headline, and have no more than 5-10 items in total. Ensure every item is truly essential for the reader, and consider numbering them in order of importance. Most people will only read the first 2 items and scan the rest.
- Make your newsletter tidy and uncluttered: Use 1 font type, 1 text size, bullet points, and graphics.
- Trim to less than 1,000 words, with each item being ≤ 200 words. Details can go into the "Go Deeper" links.
- Aim to make the reader smile or feel excited, and try to end with something funny or personal.



Workplace communication: In the modern workplace, employees expect transparency and purpose at work. You can gain a real advantage by communicating clearly and authentically.

- Use SB to write all your messages, emails, memos, and updates. People will appreciate how clearly you present your ideas and save them time.
- Encourage the entire team to do the same. Make SB a company-wide practice to save time and accelerate learning for everyone.

KEY QUOTES

"There is no better way to communicate multiple things of importance—and get people to pay attention—than a smart, zippy newsletter, all in Smart Brevity."

"This is the dawn of remote idealistic employees demanding transparency and meaning at work. Culture will be as important as strategy or execution."

KEY QUOTES

"Managers and colleagues will notice—and reward you—for making them smarter, saving time and providing helpful context."

"Communicating a company's values is now essential to both attracting and retaining the best talent."

"The way most people write emails screams 'blow me off.' But you can entice more people to read your work faster or skim more effectively if you Smart Brevity it before hitting send."

- If you're the CEO, consider a weekly employee newsletter in SB format, to align people behind your mission and values. Include:

- (i) Key updates impacting your mission and "why it matters";
- (ii) A real story of how you're impacting customers' lives;
- (iii) 5 big things each week to highlight the top priorities; and
- (iv) Recognition for your team.

- Write with candor and transparency, and poke fun at yourself if possible.



Emails: Gallup's survey found that 70% of employees want shorter communications at work. This is unsurprising since the average business user receives 126 emails daily as of 2019. To SB your emails:

- Have a short, direct subject line that tells people why they should open this email now.
- Put your most important information or request in the first sentence, to make it clear why they must read on.
- Add some context on "Why it matters". Do this consistently so people will start to look out for it.
- Use bullets to make it easier for people to skim your email.
- Bold the main words and figures that you want to stand out.
- Use clean, intuitive visuals to highlight important points.



Meetings: SB your meetings with the same principles.

- Decide if you truly need to meet, or if the issue can be addressed in a 1-1 chat.
- Set a time limit for the meeting. Most meetings can be finished in 20 minutes and you can even have 5-10 minute micro-meetings.
- The person calling the meeting should send out an email (ideally the day before) to specify a 1-sentence objective, and a bulleted agenda (with no more than 3 points).

KEY QUOTES

- Start and end meetings on time. During the meeting:
 - (i) Open with the 1-sentence objective.
 - (ii) Explain “why it matters” and help everyone to understand their role and what they can contribute.
 - (iii) Specify the decisions to be made to keep everyone focused. If anyone goes off-topic, point it out gently with a smile.
 - (iv) Be inclusive. Encourage everyone to contribute.
 - (v) When you have 2 minutes left, close the meeting by summarizing the take-aways and next steps.
- Send out a follow-up email with bullet points detailing who to do what by when.



Speeches: A great speech needn't be long, and you can SB your speeches to make them more powerful.

- Speak authentically, human-to-human. Don't rely on Powerpoint slides, notes, or teleprompters. Get people to focus on you, and rehearse looking at people in the eye.
 - (i) Focus on just ONE point or lesson. Write down your big thought in 15 words or less, then polish it using the tips earlier.
 - (ii) Open your speech by stating: “The one thing I want you to remember from my speech is...”
 - (iii) Reinforce the idea at the end: “If you were to take away only 1 thing from this speech, it will be...”
 - (iv) Bring your big idea to life using interesting statistics, great stories, and memorable quotes.
- Explain “Why it matters” and why they should pay attention.
- Number your points to create verbal bullet points in your speech.
- You can learn a lot from TED Talks. For example, can you identify the SB elements in this excerpt of networking guru Pamela Meyer's speech?

“In speeches, like life, you don't need to say a lot to make a big difference.”

“You're doing their brains' work for them—sorting the gist from the fluff.”

TED Talk by Pamela Meyer in 2011

"I don't want to alarm anybody in this room, but it's just come to my attention that the person to your right is a liar.

Ever since I wrote this book Liespotting, no one wants to meet me in person anymore, no, no, no, no, no. They say, 'It's OK, we'll email you.'

So before I get started, what I'm going to do is I'm going to clarify my goal for you. Lying is a cooperative act... Its power emerges when someone else agrees to believe the lie."

Etc.



Presentations. Simplify your presentations to amplify their impact. Use fewer visuals, less words, and delete anything that distracts the audience from your most essential points.

- An ideal presentation should have 1 big idea backed by 3-5 points. Write down your ONE desired outcome or request in 6 words or less. Then, list down the 3-5 points you must make.
 - (i) Start and end with your big idea.
 - (ii) End your presentation with a direct recap, distilled into as few words as possible. For example: "I called this meeting [or created this presentation] so I can _____"
- Develop 1 slide for each point and your overall outcome.
 - (i) Treat each slide like a billboard, so people can get the point within 3 seconds.
 - (ii) Distill down to single sentences of 20 words or less. Ideally, use minimal or no text.
- Keep it short. As a rule-of-thumb, use just 2 slides for every 20 slides you want to include. If possible, limit your presentation to 5-6 slides, with 1 point per slide.
- Use great visuals to convey your message and tell a vivid story. Arresting images get burned into the listener's brain to help them remember the message.
- Use 1 font and 1 visual style throughout.

KEY QUOTES

"So many presentations are stressful for the presenter, boring for the audience and a waste of time for both."

"You can talk, you can use slides, you can show pretty pictures. None of it matters if you don't have a crystal-clear idea of what you want the audience to remember."

"Simplify to exaggerate. Think fewer words, fewer slides, fewer visuals—destroy anything that distracts from the essential points."



Social Media. SB your social media posts so they stand out amidst the noise and clutter. The less you say, the more likely you will get clicks or shares.

- Know your audience and platforms. Pick simple, arresting images that will appeal to your audience. Align your content with what each platform values the most, e.g. Twitter loves facts and urgency, Instagram loves images with minimal text, while Facebook thrives on provocative ideas and hot news.
- Write in SB style, with a headline, 1 big idea, context, options to go deeper, and emojis that make sense. Rinse and repeat.
- Use infographics to tell complex stories with as few words as possible. People should be able to tell at a glance what you're trying to say.



Conclusion and Other Details in the Book



In a hyperconnected world filled with noise and distractions, the need for efficient, precise communication has become more crucial than ever. Smart Brevity helps you to cut through the clutter, reduce overwhelm, get heard and remembered.

- When you adopt Smart Brevity throughout your organization, it helps to create a culture of transparency and clarity, and eliminate gossip, secrecy, and confusion.



The book is filled with practical case studies, showcasing before-and-after examples of various types of communication ranging from news articles, to emails and social media posts. The also authors share their real-world experiences at Politico and Axios to illustrate Smart Brevity applications. For more details and resources, please visit SmartBrevity.com.

KEY QUOTES

"Social media is the hand-to-hand combat of attention warfare."

"On social media, you're ONLY going to tell them that one thing. Tease them with a newsy nugget. Provoke them with a surprising quote. Wow them with a memorable data point."

"A magical thing happens when you communicate crisply and transparently: You cut out all the employee gossip and pot-stirring that come from being confused or kept in the dark."